

NEW FRONTIERS, UNFORGETTABLE STORIES

As the World Cup expanded its reach, football broke new ground — creating space for underdog stories, emerging stars and a hyper-modern era shaped by tactics, technology and superstar rivalries.

GLOBALISATION OF THE GAME

The World Cup's significance as a global showpiece event continued to take shape as the tournament expanded to include more teams, starting with the 1982 edition (24 teams), before adding eight more teams from the 1998 edition onwards. The inclusion of more teams provided several fairytale stories from unheralded smaller nations and unearthed new stars beyond the Americas and Europe.

1982

SPAIN

1st

Expanded horizons: Italian defenders Antonio Cabrini (top left) and Claudio Gentile celebrate atop their teammates after Italy defeated West Germany in the 1982 final at Madrid's Bernabeu stadium. The major change at the World Cup in Spain was the expansion of the final tournament from the usual 16 teams to 24, with all six confederations receiving representation for the first time. AFP



2nd

Maradona madness: Mexican referee Rubi Vasquez (right) shows a red card to Diego Maradona (10) for foul play in a crunch World Cup clash against archrival Brazil in Barcelona. "My leg just went," Maradona would later say. THE HINDU PHOTO LIBRARY



3rd

Stain of a scandal: World Cup debutant Algeria stunned former champion West Germany in its opening group game, with Rabah Madjer scoring his nation's first-ever World Cup goal (in pic). While Algeria beat Chile in its final group match, West Germany and Austria progressed the following day after an 'arranged victory' that knocked the African side out. The incident came to be known as the 'Disgrace of Gijon'.

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